

TIGER

Panthera tigris

The largest and most striking of the big cats, the tiger is a powerful predator with almost supernatural grace and agility. Its natural range extends from the tropical jungles of Indonesia to the snowy expanses of Siberia, where the largest individuals are found. A full-grown male may weigh anything up to 300 kg (660 lb), but despite this bulk it can leap up to 10 m (33 ft) in a single bound. Adult tigers live alone, except for females with cubs – mothers watch over their young for two years or more, while teaching them vital survival skills.



SIZE 1.4–2.9 m (4½–9½ ft)

HABITAT Forests, swamps, scrub thickets, savanna, and rocky landscapes

DISTRIBUTION India to China, Siberia, the Malay peninsula, and Sumatra

DIET Mainly hoofed animals, such as deer and pigs; may also catch smaller mammals and birds

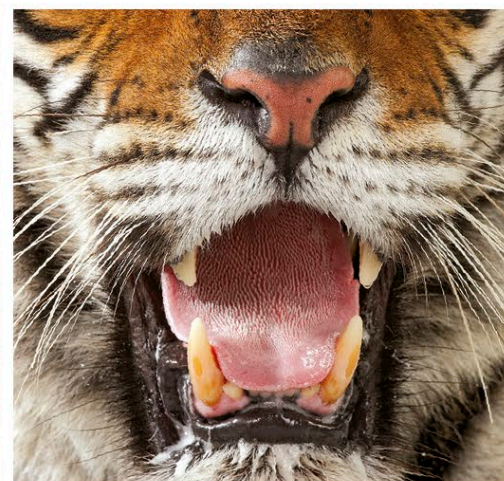
sense of smell is surprisingly poor, although tigers do use scent marks to define their territory

ROUND PUPIL >

Unlike small cats, whose pupils contract to vertical slits, tiger pupils are always round. They expand to provide excellent night vision and contract to pinpricks in bright light.

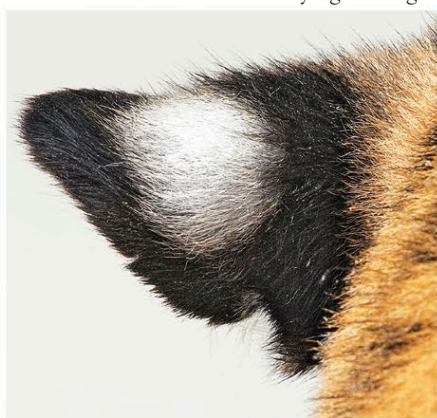
WHITE EAR FLASH ✓

The prominent white spot on the back of each ear is thought to aid communication. Cubs following their mother will notice ear movements that may signal danger.



^ STAB AND SLICE

Four long canine teeth deliver the killing bite to a tiger's prey. Blade-edged cheek teeth called carnassials slice through the meat with ease.



FORELIMBS >

The tiger has long legs and large feet, which allow it to run fast, leap large distances, and knock prey as large as oxen to the ground with a single, deadly swipe.



^ PADDED PAW

Tigers have five toes on their front paws – four of which are weight-bearing and the fifth is the dew claw. The claws are withdrawn fully into the paw when not in use.

< TAIL END

The long tail is typically held curved just above the ground. The tiger uses it to aid balance when chasing prey or climbing.



< KILLER IN STRIPES

A fiery orange coat marked with bold black stripes provides superb camouflage as the tiger moves through sun-dappled vegetation. The white tigers seen in zoos are usually bred in captivity and are extremely rare in the wild. Indeed, tigers have been hunted almost to extinction; globally, there are fewer than 3,900 left in the wild.

long whiskers allow the tiger to feel its way through dense undergrowth in almost total darkness